

Jessel Leaves, But Where in Heck Is Berg?

By JIMMY BRESLIN

NEW YORK, Aug. 28 (NEA). —George Jessel was given an impossible task. As chairman



Mel Allen

of the U. S. Committee for Baseball in Israel, he was asked to fly to Tel Aviv with the first baseball equipment that country had seen. Which was easy enough. The hard part came when his group asked him to find Moe Berg, the old catcher.

"They want Berg to spend eight months teaching the kids over there how to play baseball," George was saying. "But how am I going to find him?"

Berg, for 20 years a short-stop, catcher and coach with the White Sox and Red Sox, speaks eight languages, has three or four different degrees and would create a riot as head of an Israeli baseball school.

It is normally easier to find

new money than Berg. The Yankees, once seeking Moe for an old timer's game, had to have Mel Allen request over TV that people look for him. A bridge toll collector at Orient Point, L. I., came up with Moe the time. But usually it is impossible to locate the combination walking encyclopedia and detective magazine.

Jessel, however, appears to be well qualified.

When John McGraw was manager of the New York Giants one of his major aims was to find a Jewish ball player. The gate possibilities, McGraw figured, would be unlimited with such an attraction.

So when a second baseman named Andy Cohen arrived in the 1928 season, and started off at a murderous clip, McGraw was elated.

"We," he said to George Jessel, a Giant batboy in 1910, "have it made."

But they started to curve Cohen after a time and one afternoon Jessel watched as Andy struck out for the second time with men on base and the

Giants were routed, 8-0.

After the game he and McGraw hustled to Belmont Park to catch the last half of the day's card and in the seventh race a considerable bundle was put on a horse ridden by Sammy Renick. The horse got no place and McGraw was particularly displeased with Sammy's ride.

Jessel glumly leaned over to him. "John," he said softly, "they can't ride, either."

"We never stopped trying," Jessel says. "A couple of years later I dug up a guy named John Levi. He was an Indian from the Haskell Institute, but McGraw thought we could put him over. But the boys covering the club began to suspect he wasn't Jewish. The other batters started to suspect he wasn't much of a pitcher."

Schmiel Itzek enthusiastically endorsed the idea Jessel and McGraw were trying to put over. Schmiel was a New York character who was always being kidded about his accent. Conscious of it, Schmiel would answer, "Vat's metter? Your mudder and father vas Indians?"